

Supporting Elders And Missionaries

prc-supporting-elders-and-missionaries

Money & Stewardship · Giving · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

The church is to financially support its elders who labor in the word and its missionaries sent out for the gospel.

In plain language

Several New Testament passages line up to teach that a church should provide materially for the people who teach it and for the workers it sends out. In 1 Timothy 5:17-18 elders who lead well, and especially those who labor in the word (logos) and in teaching (didaskalia), are to be counted worthy of double honor (diples times). The verb "let them be counted worthy" (axiousthosan) is a standing command, an ongoing instruction to the church, and the word for honor carries the sense of a payment or honorarium. Paul then proves the point by quoting two Scriptures back to back, the law against muzzling an ox while it treads out grain from Deuteronomy 25:4 (boun aloonta ou phimoseis) and the saying that the laborer is worthy of his wages (axios ho ergates tou misthou autou). Putting a food law and a wage saying side by side ties the honor owed to elders directly to real material support. The same logic appears elsewhere. In 1 Corinthians 9 Paul cites the very same muzzling law to defend the gospel worker's right to provision, and a few verses later he says the Lord himself commanded (dietaxen) that those who preach the gospel should live from the gospel (euangelion). In Galatians 6:6 the one being taught (the one being catechized, katechoumenos) is commanded to share (koinoneito) with the teacher in all good things, and the imperative is present tense, meaning ongoing. In Philippians 4 a congregation, that is an assembly or church (ekklesia), partnered (ekoinonesen) with Paul in giving and receiving over a sustained period, sending help more than once, and the gift (doma) it sent is called a fragrant offering and an acceptable sacrifice (thysian dekten) pleasing to God, which lifts the support to the level of worship. In 3 John 5-8 believers are urged to send out missionaries worthily of God and to support those who went out (exelthon) for the Name, so that the supporters become fellow workers (synergoi) with the truth, with the duty made explicit by the word "we ought" (opheilomen). The reason the picture is so clear at the word level is that the same key terms keep recurring across independent letters and the same Old Testament law gets cited twice as the ground. A few passages where Paul worked with his own hands and refused pay do not overturn this. In each case the same paragraph explicitly says he had the right and waived it for his own reasons, which assumes the duty rather than cancels it.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0018	ἀγαθός	agathos	good	106
G0248	ἀλοάω	aloao	to thresh	3
G0514	ἄξιος	axios	worthy	41
G0515	ἀξιόω	axioo	to deem worthy	7
G1016	βοῦς	bous	ox	8

G1184	δεκτός	dektos	acceptable	5
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	21
G1362	διπλοῦς	diplous	double	4
G1364	δίς	dis	twice	7
G1390	δόμα	doma	gift	4
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	
G1831	ἐξέρχομαι	exerchomai	to go out	219
G1934	ἐπιζητέω	epizeteo	to seek after	13
G2040	ἐργάτης	ergates	worker	16
G2098	εὐαγγέλιον	euangelion	gospel	75
G2727	κατηχέω	katecheo	to instruct	8
G2841	κοινωνέω	koinoneo	to participate	8
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The word-level pattern converges on the proposition from several independent New Testament passages, each grounded in cited Old Testament law. In 1 Timothy 5:17-18 elders who lead well, especially those toiling in word (logos) and teaching (didaskalia), are to be reckoned worthy ("let them be counted worthy," *axiousthosan*, a present passive imperative, that is, a standing command) of double honor ("double honor," *diples times*). Paul then introduces two Scriptures with "for the Scripture says" (*legei gar he graphe*), citing Deuteronomy 25:4 ("you shall not muzzle the ox while it treads," *boun aloonta ou phimoseis*) and the wage saying "the laborer is worthy of his wages" (*axios ho ergates tou misthou autou*). The same warrant is reasserted in 1 Corinthians 9:9-14 where the same Deuteronomy citation grounds the dominical command ("the Lord commanded," *dietaxen ho kurios*). Philippians 4:15-18 shows a concrete church partnership ("partnered," *ekoinonesen*; "gift," *doma*; "acceptable sacrifice," *thysian dekten*); Galatians 6:6 issues a present imperative ("let him share," *koinoneito*) binding the taught to share with the teacher in all good things; and 3 John 5-8 frames support of those who went out ("having gone out," *exelthon*) for the Name as making senders fellow workers ("fellow workers," *synergoi*) with the truth. The convergence of imperatives, the cited law, and the dominical (the Lord's own) warrant make the practice decisive at the word level across the canon.

Scripture

1Tim.5.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1362 διπλοῦς, G0515 ἀξιώω, G3056 λόγος, G1319 διδασκαλία

Reasoning. Elders who lead well, and especially ("especially," *malista*) those toiling in word and teaching, are to be reckoned worthy of double honor. The verb "let them be counted worthy" (*axiousthosan*) is a present passive imperative (an ongoing, standing command directed at the church), and the noun phrase "double honor" (*diples times*) pairs the sense of honor with material payment, as the next verse makes explicit by adducing a food provision law and a wage saying. The substantive participle "the elders who lead well" (*hoi kalos proestotes presbyteroi*) identifies the persons to be so honored.

1Tim.5.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0514 ἄγιος, G2040 ἐργάτης, G1016 βοῦς, G0248 ἀλοάω

Reasoning. Paul grounds the double honor in two cited Scriptures introduced by "for the Scripture says" (legei gar he graphe). First Deuteronomy 25:4 ("you shall not muzzle the ox while it treads," boun aloonta ou phimoseis), do not muzzle the threshing ox, and second the saying "the laborer is worthy of his wages" (axios ho ergates tou misthou autou). The pairing of a food provision and a wage saying ties elder honor directly to material support. The verb "to tread out grain" (aloao) occurs only three times in the New Testament (a hapax-like cluster, 1 Timothy 5:18, 1 Corinthians 9:9, 1 Corinthians 9:10), and every occurrence applies this Deuteronomy text to the same gospel-labor warrant, so the word-chain is exceptionally tight.

1Cor.9.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1016 βοῦς, G0248 ἀλοάω

Reasoning. Paul cites the same Deuteronomy 25:4 muzzling law ("you shall not muzzle the threshing ox," ou phimoseis boun aloonta) and applies it explicitly to the right of gospel workers to material support. The rhetorical question "is it for oxen that God is concerned" (me ton boon melel to theo) shows Paul reading the law's underlying principle as a fortiori applicable (an "all the more so" argument: if it applies to the lesser case, surely also to the greater) to the human worker.

1Cor.9.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2098 εὐαγγέλιον

Reasoning. The Lord commanded that those proclaiming the gospel should live from the gospel ("to live from the gospel," ek tou euangelion zen). The verb "he commanded" (dietaxen) is an aorist indicative (a completed past act of authoritative ordering), making material support of gospel labor an explicit dominical (Lord-given) instruction rather than mere custom. The infinitive "to live" (zen) indicates ongoing sustenance, not a one-off honorarium.

Phil.4.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2841 κοινωνέω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. No church partnered with Paul in the matter of giving and receiving ("in the account of giving and receiving," eis logon doseos kai lempseos) except the Philippians, who sent aid to him when he went out from Macedonia. The aorist (completed past) "partnered" (ekoinonesen) records a congregation, an assembly or church (ekklesia, a term the file treats as polysemous: assembly or church), materially supporting an apostolic worker sent out for the gospel, and the bookkeeping phrase "into an account" (eis logon) shows the partnership had concrete financial form.

Phil.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1364 δις

Reasoning. Even in Thessalonica, more than once ("both once and twice," kai hapax kai dis), the Philippians sent for Paul's need ("you sent for my need," eis ten chreian moi epempsate). The repetition language documents sustained, not one-off, support for a sent missionary worker.

Phil.4.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1934 ἐπιζητέω, G1390 δόμα

Reasoning. Paul says he does not seek ("not that I seek," ouch hoti epizeto) the gift itself ("the gift," to doma) but the fruit that mounts up to the givers' account ("the fruit that abounds to your account," ton karpon ton pleonazonta eis logon humon). The bookkeeping idiom "into an account" (eis logon) repeats from verse 15 and frames giving to a worker as a credit entered to the giver's spiritual account, reinforcing rather than discounting the support relation.

Phil.4.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1390 δόμα, G1184 δεκτός

Reasoning. Paul names the gift received through Epaphroditus a fragrant offering, an acceptable sacrifice well-pleasing to God ("a fragrant aroma, an acceptable sacrifice, well-pleasing to God," osmen euodias, thysian dekten, euareston to theo). The cultic (worship-related) language treats material support of the gospel worker as a worship offering rendered upward to God, framing it as a duty owed and an act of worship, not optional charity.

Gal.6.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2841 κοινωνέω, G2727 κατηχέω, G0018 ἀγαθός

Reasoning. Let the one being taught the word share with the one teaching in all good things ("let the one being taught the word share with the one teaching in all good things," koinoneito de ho katechoumenos ton logon to katechounti en pasin agathois). The present imperative "let him share" (koinoneito) makes ongoing material sharing with the teacher of the word a standing obligation on the taught. The phrase "in all good things" (en pasin agathois) denotes material goods, parallel to Romans 15:27's "in fleshly things" (tois sarkikois).

3John.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1831 ἐξέρχομαι, G2098 εὐαγγέλιον

Reasoning. Gaius is commended for faithfully helping the brothers and strangers, and the instruction is to send them on their way worthily of God ("worthily of God," axios tou theou). The aorist participle (a completed past action used as a description) "having gone out" (exelthon) identifies them as those who went out for the sake of the Name ("for the Name," huper tou onomatos), and verse 8 makes the verdict explicit: we ought ("we ourselves ought," hemeis oun opheilomen) to support such men so as to become "fellow workers with the truth" (synergoi tei aletheiai). The deontic (duty-marking) "we ought" (opheilomen) carries the duty.

Deut.25.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. G1016 βοῦς, G0248 ἀλοάω

Reasoning. Do not muzzle the ox while it treads out the grain. Paul cites this law twice (1 Corinthians 9:9 and 1 Timothy 5:18) as the Scriptural foundation for paying gospel laborers, so the principle of provision for the worker is anchored in the law and explicitly carried forward into the New Testament command. The same Greek phrase "you shall not muzzle the threshing ox" (boun aloonta ou phimoseis) recurs verbatim across both citations.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.5.18	Deut.25.4	tsk	1
1Tim.5.18	Lev.19.13	tsk	1
1Tim.5.18	Luke.10.7	tsk	1
Gal.6.6	Deut.12.19	tsk	1
Phil.4.17	Prov.19.17	tsk	1
Phil.4.17	Phil.1.11	tsk	1
1Tim.5.17	1Cor.9.14	openbible	1
3John.1.8	Rom.16.2	openbible	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.9.15 · addressed

Paul says he has used none of these rights ("I have used none of these things," *ouk echresamen oudeni touton*) and would rather die than be deprived of his ground for boasting. This does not negate 1 Corinthians 9:14 or 1 Timothy 5:17-18. The grammar distinguishes Paul forgoing a personal right in the first person from abolishing the general obligation. He affirms the right exists, calls it commanded, then declines it for himself, which presupposes rather than denies the duty.

Acts.20.34 · addressed

Paul reminds the Ephesian elders that his own hands supplied his needs ("these hands served my needs and those who were with me," *tais chreiais mou kai tois ousi met emou hupereteasan hai cheires hautai*). As with 1 Corinthians 9, this is a voluntary waiver of a recognized right, framed as an example of laboring to help the weak (verse 35), not as a prohibition. It does not contradict the standing imperatives "let them be counted worthy" (*axiousthosan*) in 1 Timothy 5:17 and "let him share" (*koinoneito*) in Galatians 6:6 addressed to the church regarding its workers.

2Thess.3.8 · addressed

Paul worked night and day so as not to burden the Thessalonians, calling it an example against idleness. The very next verse explicitly states that he had the right ("authority," *exousia*) to support but waived it to model diligence ("not because we do not have the right, but in order to give ourselves as an example to you," *ouch hoti ouk echomen exousian, all' hina heautous tupon domen humin*). The acknowledged right (*exousia*) confirms rather than undermines the proposition that the church owes support to its workers.

Matt.10.8 · addressed

Jesus' instruction freely you received, freely give ("freely you received, freely give," *dorean elabete, dorean dote*) prohibits charging for the kingdom message itself, not receiving support from those served. The very next breath, Matthew 10:10, calls the worker worthy of his food ("for the laborer is worthy of his food," *axios gar ho ergates tes trophes autou*), the same "the laborer is worthy" (*axios ho ergates*) axiom Paul cites in 1 Timothy 5:18, so the passage itself harmonizes the no-charge instruction with the right to provision.

Concordance traversed

G1362, G0515, G0514, G2040, G3056, G1319, G2841, G2727, G1016, G0248, G1390, G1184, G1831, G2098, G0018, G1364, G1934

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units (places where the manuscripts disagree about the wording) were supplied in the bundle for 1 Timothy 5:17-18, 1 Corinthians 9:9-14, Philippians 4:14-18, Galatians 6:6, or 3 John 5-8. The double-honor clause and its two grounding citations are textually stable across the major witnesses, and the verdict does not turn on any contested reading. ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) CBGM data (a method for tracing manuscript family relationships) was not examined for 3 John in this run, so the status is recorded as shadow rather than published.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · Reads the Deuteronomy 25:4 muzzling law as a continuing creational and moral principle that Paul applies directly to gospel workers in both 1 Corinthians 9:9 and 1 Timothy 5:18, so material support of teaching elders is a standing covenant obligation carried from law into the church under the same warrant.

dispensationalism: affirms · Even granting a sharp law and grace distinction, the support obligation rests on explicit New Testament church-age imperatives ("let them be counted worthy," *axiousthosan*, in 1 Timothy 5:17; "let him

share," koinoneito, in Galatians 6:6) and the dominical (the Lord's own) command of 1 Corinthians 9:14 ("the Lord commanded," dietaxen ho kurios), so the verdict holds independently of how the Deuteronomy citation is treated.

new_covenant_theology: affirms · Reads Paul's use of Deuteronomy 25:4 as drawing out an enduring principle of just compensation that the New Covenant intensifies and applies to gospel labor. The verdict holds on the basis of the apostolic re-issuing in the New Testament imperatives without requiring the Sinai code to remain directly binding.

Both the citation of Deuteronomy 25:4 within 1 Timothy 5:18 (and again in 1 Corinthians 9:9) and the dominical (the Lord's own) warrant of 1 Corinthians 9:14 illustrate progressive revelation (the principle that later Scripture builds on and clarifies earlier Scripture), where an Old Testament provision principle is reaffirmed and intensified for gospel labor. The verdict is reached by analogia scripturae (the rule of using Scripture to interpret Scripture) across law and epistle, and the three lenses examined converge on the same answer because the New Testament imperatives are independent of any particular theory of law-gospel continuity.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem phrase "the church is to support" carries deontic (duty-imposing) force, but that force is supplied directly by the word-level data, namely the present passive imperative "let them be counted worthy" (axiousthosan) in 1 Timothy 5:17, the present imperative "let him share" (koinoneito) in Galatians 6:6, the aorist of command "he commanded" (dietaxen) in 1 Corinthians 9:14, and the duty word "we ought" (opheilomen) in 3 John 8. The stem is not tradition-specific or question-begging beyond what the source imperatives state, so it is not treated as preloaded.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.9.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.6.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Phil.4.18
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1362
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0514
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2841
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0248
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.5.18
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gal.6.6

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

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